



Anish Pathiyil

anish.p@thehindu.co.in

Away from the champagne popping, celebratory donuts and the coronation of a new World Champion, the 2025 Formula One season also became a canvas for strokes of improvement and illustrations of tenacity.

With the imminent onset of new regulations in 2026, most expected teams to put a lid on development early in the season and focus on the subsequent car. However, despite the rewards being temporary, many midfield teams made steady progress through the year, climbing the constructors' standings.



Williams made the most headway. The 137 points achieved by the team this season were more than eight times its tally from the previous year. "Our future isn't racing for 8th, 9th or 7th. Our future is racing for championships. You'll see we're making sacrifices for the next few years to bring ourselves to where we need to be," Williams team principal James Vowles had told *Sportstar* on the sidelines of the Saudi Arabia Grand Prix in April this year. Yet the team still managed to rake in more points than it had across the last seven seasons combined.

"The Williams story, for me, underlines the importance of drivers. They have not had two top drivers since 2016," said former F1 driver-turned broadcaster Karun Chandhok. With Felipe Massa and Valtteri Bottas behind the wheel, the Grove-based team had finished fifth in 2016 with 138 points.

"Carlos Sainz was winning races last year at Ferrari. He's really at the top of his game. Having him alongside Alex Albon, suddenly they are driving the [Williams] team forward," he added.

Albon and Sainz finished eighth and ninth in the drivers' championship with 73 and 64 points respectively. The last time the British team had two drivers in the top 10 was in 2015. In April, Vowles termed his driver pairing 'a breath of fresh air'. "Neither one wants anything more than for the team to be successful, which means that every

Measured promise: Isack Hadjar's rookie season offered speed without noise, and ambition without excess. AFP

meeting we have is about the greater good. How do we make it better next year? What's our direction of travel? What can I do to help?" he had said. Sainz also bagged two podiums during the year, in Baku and Qatar, breaking the team's unwanted four-year streak.

The season, however, ended on a slightly sour note. Both drivers failed to finish in the top 10 at the Abu Dhabi Grand Prix, and Sainz said it underlined how much more remained to be done to replicate the success of the 20th century.

"I hope it serves as a good wake-up call to the team, that after a podium, you come back to Abu Dhabi, and we were quite weak. I'm actually happy this happened, so we go into the winter without falling asleep," Sainz told reporters.

Forward steps

Despite the early-season melee involving Red Bull's second driver seat, which saw Yuki Tsunoda replace Liam Lawson after just two races, Racing Bulls forged a strong campaign, doubling its points haul from last year. Leading the charge for the Faenza-based outfit was rookie Isack Hadjar, who bagged 51 points in his debut season, including a podium finish at Zandvoort.

The diminutive Frenchman will